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REL332 Encountering Japanese Religions

From Dualism to Non-Dualism: A Cross-Cultural Reflection on Zen Practice in Japan

Thesis Statement: *"How has my encounter with non-dualism during my Maymester in Japan studying Zen Buddhism shifted my Western binary thinking, and how have I actively engaged with these insights in my daily life?"*

I. Introduction

As I sit on my 15-hour flight to London, I reflect on my past month in Japan. I remember registering for this Maymester to study Zen Buddhism with two intentions: to return to Japan, a place that left a deep impression on me at age twelve, and to quiet my restless, perfectionist mind that sought an answer to the meaning of life. My fascination with Japan stemmed from a romanticised memory of trying on a kimono in Kyoto at the age of twelve. I recall the deliberate layering of fabric, beginning with the undergarment, then carefully wrapping the kimono around the body, left over right, and meticulously tying it together with a sash called an "obi". I loved how the simple act of putting on this traditional Japanese clothing carried so much meaning: the storied tapestry of a culture rooted in respect, artistry, and connection to nature. I vowed to my mother that I would return to Japan.

Nine years later, I embarked on this Maymester. I arrived with a fragmented view of Zen Buddhism, drawn from books like *Wabi Sabi* by Beth Kempton, haiku poetry, and Studio Ghibli films like *Spirited Away*. I associated Zen with words like "serenity" and "enlightenment" without fully grasping what it meant or how it felt. Fortunately, this Maymester shifted my understanding through the teachings of the Sōtō Zen sect and first-hand experience of the concept of non-dualism. Through zazen meditation, temple visits, conversations with monks and lay practitioners, and immersion in contemporary Japanese life, I began to experience a collapse of the binaries that once structured my Western, Christian-influenced worldview. I was able to assuage my anxieties and become more present in my life. I surrendered the need for attainment and learnt to appreciate the endless possibilities in the now.

This paper asks: *"How has my encounter with non-dualism during my Maymester in Japan studying Zen Buddhism shifted my Western binary thinking, and how have I actively engaged with these insights in my daily life?"*

In this paper, I argue that embodied engagement with non-dualism offers a powerful reorientation of how we experience the self, reality, and religious toleration with broader benefits for interreligious dialogue that invite us to reimagine our epistemological foundations beyond dualistic frameworks.

II. Theoretical Framework and Background

• Non-dualism

I came across the concept of non-dualism during our lecture by Kiyozumi Seijun Ishii Sensei at Komazawa University. Non-dualism was explained in *Fukan Zazenji*, written by Eihei Dōgen, the founder of Sōtō Zen. Dōgen quotes a dialogue between a monk and Chinese Zen master Yakusan

Igen, expressing the essential art of zazen as “Thinking (*shiryō*) of not-thinking (*fu-shiriyō*)...Beyond thinking (*hi-shiryō*)”. This paradoxical statement uses three distinct terms to describe one act. Upon our first discussion, I was unable to wrap my mind around this concept that seemed to contradict my frameworks of logic and identity. In the Q&A that ensued, I sought to rationalize this non-logical statement and was left hopeless as Ishii sensei could not answer my questions along with my reasoning and so I continued to approach Zen with a fixed mindset.

Another academic encounter with non-dualism was with Yuko Wakayama Yamada, the abbess of Shokakuji Temple. During our seminar, she expressed her respect and admiration for her Catholic sisters and brothers whilst engaging with Zen Buddhism. Her outlook was neither rigid nor syncretic; instead, she embodied a holistic sensibility. This was reflected in her autobiographical article *One Nun, Two Faiths*, where Yuko states, “I don’t mean to imply that Catholicism is bad, and Buddhism is good... I still respect my Catholic sisters and brothers...We are practising in different ways, but we are still connected”. Hearing her approach, I was touched by the level of tolerance for both religions, but I struggled to accept her ability to make room for both beliefs. I found it illogical for Yuko to have converted from being a nun to a monk, and still hold respect for Catholicism. My binary thinking dictated it had to be one or the other, not both.

• Western Dualism

The concept of non-dualism contrasted drastically with the Western conceptual binaries I was accustomed to. The dichotomies of right versus wrong, life versus death, divine versus the self, are categories inherited from my Christian upbringing and reinforced by dominant Western epistemologies.

During my literature review, existing scholarship examined the relationship between religion and our dualistic mental experience. In the study of *Origins of Dualism and Nondualism in the History of Religion and Spiritual Practice*, Henning argues that the Western religious and philosophical tradition has cultivated a metaphysical framework that privileges separation and opposition, structuring reality into hierarchical dualisms that obscure the possibility of holistic thinking (Henning and Henning 2022). It was evident that at the beginning of this Maymester, these inherited constructs shaped my thinking so innately that I resisted the ambiguous and unfamiliar spiritual practice of Zen.

My research pushed me to reflect on my unconscious binary thinking. Much of Catholic doctrine is rooted in moral dualism, and this dichotomous mode of understanding had extended into my broader cognitive framework. I often interpreted life through fixed oppositions, success or failure, self or other, mind or body, control or chaos. This need for perfection and realization of one extreme or the other often left me with a feeling of defeat and frustration that would transform into anxious thoughts. I believe these binary structures are deeply embedded in the Western psyche and impede recognition of interconnectedness emphasized in nondual traditions like Zen Buddhism.

• Why does it matter?

It was important to recognize the preconceptions deeply rooted in the Western psyche if I was to proceed with my Zen practice. Non-dualism offered a mode of being that did not seek to resolve or categorize but just to be in the present moment. It asserted that ultimate reality is a unified, undivided whole, each of us an important piece in the bigger puzzle.

I was only able to accept this through the direct experience of zazen seated meditation. Now looking back on this Maymester, I believe non-dualism has had an unforeseen effect on my daily life. My shift has not been immediate or absolute, but I have begun to let go of the need to perfect, arrive, or fix, instead learning to observe, participate, and be.

I have not accomplished the goals that led me to Japan— my mind is still restless, and there is always more Japanese culture to discover— but I no longer frame this as failure. This course has been a journey that is not a path to self-optimization, but an ongoing process of self-dissolution and the acceptance of impermanence encompassed in Zen Buddhism.

I believe non-dualism is an essential foundation of Zen Buddhism, accommodating the need to focus on the dynamic and valuable power of the *now*.

III. Methodology

This research employs an autoethnographic methodology, using my embodied experiences and personal reflections during a month-long immersion in Japan to explore the concept of non-dualism in Zen Buddhism. Drawing from course materials, lectures, and direct field experiences— a zazen retreat in Saitama— I trace specific instances where my psychological orientation shifted from a Western dualistic thought to a more holistic, non-dual awareness.

- **Limitations**

While the subjective nature of this study and my Christian upbringing present interpretive limitations, these very lenses offer a unique cross-cultural perspective. My limited Japanese proficiency also constrained deeper dialogue with practitioners; however, by focusing on a few concrete moments of internal change, this research aims to reveal how lived, rather than abstract, non-dualism can quietly transform everyday consciousness.

IV. Experiential Narrative and Key Turning Points

- **Zazen Seated Meditation**

The idea of non-dualism slowly became clear through the practice of zazen, seated meditation. Zazen is considered the true form of the self and non-doing or not-action, it demands a set of step-by-step instructions: sitting placing the base of your spine at the center of a *zafu* (cushion), adopting the lotus position, keeping an upright posture, and forming the cosmic mudra with your hands as you stare downward at a 45-degree angle keeping your eyes open. Our first zazen meditation was undeniably uncomfortable and I initially resisted the idea of “thinking of non-thinking” as my thoughts raced uncontrollably.

This experience contrasts with my past attempts at transcendental meditation, where I was taught to repeat a personalised mantra with my eyes closed. During these sessions, I would often hyperfocus on the mantra or slip into a quasi-sleep state.

In contrast, zazen demanded full wakefulness; it was physically uncomfortable to sit on our *zafu* in silence with a numbing foot and restless mind. And yet, there was something deeply grounding about the detailed ritual: entering the zendō, holding your hands in *shashu* position and stepping forward with your left foot at the left side of the entrance, and bowing *gasshō* toward the altar before heading to our seat. These small but precise gestures tied mind and body together in a way that felt more integrated than anything I had previously practised.

In these sessions, I began to accept “thinking of non-thinking”; as I sat, reflecting, and observing my thoughts and feeling an energy surmount my body as if I was transcending space and time. It felt like I was glowing. Despite the challenge of staying awake as I stared at the wall, there came a point where time slipped away, and before I knew it, the bell was rung to signify the end of zazen. I found relief in uncrossing my legs, but also a sadness in letting go of that moment of mental repose found in stillness.

I enjoyed the actions accompanying zazen: for instance, *gasshō* (holding the palms and fingers of both hands together with your arms slightly away from your chest and elbows extended outward from your sides) held an expression of respect, faith and devotion. The two hands (duality) are joined together to express one mind.

During zazen, the words “thinking of non-thinking” echoed as I sat observing my stream of consciousness; thoughts would appear, and yet I would not cling, chase, or push them away but let them ebb in and out of my mind. Once zazen ended, I felt a cathartic release, taking a step back as I set out for the day.

• Principles of Monastic Life

Another meaningful encounter with non-dualism emerged through my immersion in monastic life during our stay at Eihei-ji Monastery in Fukui, as well as through the zazen retreat at Shokakuji Temple in Saitama. Due to the constraints of this paper, I have chosen to concentrate on my experience in Saitama. We stayed two nights at Shokakuji Temple, practising zazen, chanting the Heart Sutra, eating the Zen way *shojin ryori* using Buddha bowls, carrying out *samu* physical work, performing *shodo*, a meditative form of calligraphy, taking the opportunity to ask questions to the abbot and revelling in the nature that surrounded the temple.

The Saitama retreat immersed us in nature, hills overlapping one another as we listened to the nearby stream and watched the colourful koi fish swim. During our discussion time, the abbot repeatedly spoke of our interconnectedness in the universe, encouraging a non-anthropocentric view of existence, where humans are intertwined with the environment they live in. Practising zazen in this remote temple offered a place to let go, find stillness, and a feeling of numbness.

All the activities we participated in demanded absolute awareness and transcended the need for focus, seeking to just be. The concept of non-dualism unfolded before me as I worked in comfortable silence, bringing my attention to the task at hand. There was not before and after but only the ever-present now.

As I drew the outlines of each script during *shodo*, I had recurring thoughts, emotions and stresses of life flow in and out, but I would bring back my attention to the pen and paper, using my breath to recenter myself.

Our stay consisted of a strict schedule of activities signaled by the ringing of the bell which allowed one to humble the “self” and integrate one’s awareness into even the most mundane acts. I found that these activities dismantled the dualism of self vs other, mind vs body, sacred vs profane, revealing the fluid continuity between inner experience and outer world. During a period in which I faced a lot of stress in my romantic relationship, worry and pain, I was able to ground myself, see the bigger picture, and not give in to destructive thoughts.

One memorable moment was when I was crying outside the temple and the abbot caught sight of me and approached to ask what was going on. I disclosed my worries, and his words were not

one of reassurance but of plain truth: he stated, “You know what to do, so now do it”. This simple phrase encompasses the lesson I learnt in Saitama: the power of staying strong-minded, disciplined and in the now. The idea is to remove the constructed “self” and focus on the possibilities of choice that lie at our fingertips.

- **Contemporary Japan**

The practice of zazen seamlessly slipped into my daily life, cultivating a heightened awareness of my surroundings and an experiential sense of non-dualism. A particularly reflective moment occurred at Aoyama Cemetery, where journaling amid the shrines prompted me to reflect on the nature of impermanence. The stillness of the environment invited a meditative state akin to seated zazen, during which I found myself weeping blissful tears. The wind carried the soft notes of a flute played by a man commemorating his loved ones. I have begun to truly appreciate the quiet beauty that surrounds us, accessible only when the mind is free of cluttered thoughts and emotions.

This sense of non-duality resurfaced more explicitly at the Mori Art Museum’s *Machine Love: Video Game, AI, and the Contemporary Self* exhibition, particularly in Lu Yang’s digital artwork *DOKU*, meaning “born alone, die alone”. The avatar’s journey through Buddhist realms blurred distinctions between life and death, self and non-self, aligning with the Buddhist concept of *anatta* (no-self). The piece inspired profound introspection, encouraging the audience to let go of their ego and adopt a more intentional and compassionate way of being.

V. Analysis: Transformation in Thought and Being

This transformation may not have the dramatic grandeur often associated with spiritual awakenings, but as Kaoru Nonomura writes in his memoir, *Eat Sleep Sit*, “Now when a mosquito lands on me, I hesitate for a second before killing it.” Its subtlety is precisely what makes it profound. Nonomura’s reflections underscore a central tenet of Zen: living mindfully and courageously in the present. He writes, “At Eihei-ji I learned the courage to affirm everything in the past and the joy of living mindfully in the present, out of which the future will be born.” These ‘three’ temporal phases form a continuous yet multifaceted dimension that shapes our lives and those of others. Through zazen, I am reminded that the present is essentially a gift; every second offers the possibility of choice—how to care, what to think, and what to do.

My encounter with non-dualism did not arrive as a single, life-altering epiphany, but as a slow erosion of certainty and separation. What began as a theoretical discomfort with Dōgen’s paradoxical language, “thinking of non-thinking”, evolved into a lived recognition that much of my suffering stemmed from clinging to binaries. Oppositions such as life vs death, good vs wrong, success vs failure, governed my internal world, shaped by Christian moral schemas and Western rationalism. But through the embodied practice of zazen, I began to witness a gradual dissolution of those inner divisions. There was no goal in meditation but to be present. I noticed my thoughts without judgment or the need to rationalize them. This reorientation has not caused me to abandon my identity, but it has led to a loosening of its grip and the concept of ‘self’. In moments of anxiety, I recall the principle of beyond thinking as a way to respond rather than react. The adoption of non-dualism does not mean I have renounced my Christian beliefs; if anything, it has reinforced my faith, but it has also taught me not to strive for perfection as an endpoint. I can confidently say that

this transformation continues to unfold, it is iterative, not absolute, and I shall strive to keep practising.

VI. Discussion & Conclusion

Overall, my encounter with non-dualism in Zen Buddhism illustrates the potential for interreligious dialogue. I believe figures like Yuko Wakayama embody a model of religious pluralism where contradiction is not a threat but a space for fostering tolerance in increasingly diverse and interconnected societies.

This paper concentrates on how embodied spiritual practice, such as zazen seated meditation, is a direct approach to understanding non-dualism and challenging the dominance of Western rationalism in religious studies. Comparative theology often operates through abstraction, but Zen's insistence on lived experience calls for pedagogies that focus on the active and dynamic present implementation. Zazen invites one to "just sit" as one's thoughts arise and pass, emphasising the role of observing without grasping.

Personally, although my anxieties and self-critical tendencies still arise, they no longer dominate unchallenged. I observe my emotions rather than react and implement the tools used during my zazen meditations, such as taking deep breaths and "thinking of non-thinking". I find that I have slowly detached myself from identification with the mind, recognising the screen of thought for what it is and moved beyond the ego to find a place of oneness with all that is.

The practice of non-dualism begins anew each day, upon waking and with each challenge that arises. Perhaps the experience of "thinking of non-thinking" can best be understood as that liminal moment upon waking, when we hover between the conscious and dream realms, immersed in a state of peaceful emptiness.

I hope that this personal inquiry stands as a microcosm through which one might begin to appreciate the nuances and complexities of Zen Buddhism, not as a finished understanding, but as an ongoing, evolving process. Like Zen itself, this paper is a work in progress– an invitation to further explore how individuals can meaningfully engage with non-dualism in both spiritual and academic contexts.

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